foreign peers be so down on India. I realized we needed change and felt Modi was the man to effect that change,' he told me.

Akhil was not alone. One of the striking features of Team Modi was how young many of them were. IIM and IIT graduates, lawyers and accountants —they symbolized the energies of a new, younger India. Conventional wisdom was that the educated young had become cynical of public life and had switched off from politics. The back-room team of Modi challenged that assumption.

Interestingly, Rahul, too, had tried to reach out to the educated young India while building his election team. But there was a crucial difference. Modi's young guns were not expected to involve themselves in micromanaging political strategy. Their task was to operate in more familiar territory—technology innovations, Internet, social media, made-for-TV events, statistical data interpretation. The nitty-gritty of election management—be it campaign planning, door-to-door campaigns or ticket distribution—was left to the full-time RSS and BJP political workers. In Rahul's case, his Ivy League 'boys' actually took over the task of running the election campaign instead of leaving that to the older, more experienced, Congress leaders.

Not surprisingly, a prime target group for CAG was the 'youth'. In June, CAG held a closed-door meeting on 'Youth and Leadership' in Ahmedabad where the guest speakers included former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam and the HDFC group chairman Deepak Parekh. Modi sat in the audience through the day just listening to the speeches. In October, a one-day youth summit called Manthan was organized with the stated goal of setting the agenda for 'young India' in the 2014 elections. With an aggressive Facebook campaign, Manthan was able to attract lakhs of visitors to its site. 'We invited several leaders for the summit, even Rahul Gandhi, but he chose not to attend,' claims Kishore. Modi did come, speak and, predictably, was the showstopper. A journalist friend in the audience described the mood as akin to a rock concert.

It was clear by now that Modi had captured hearts and minds in urban India, especially among the young. A clever mix of town hall-type speaking